

The atmosphere

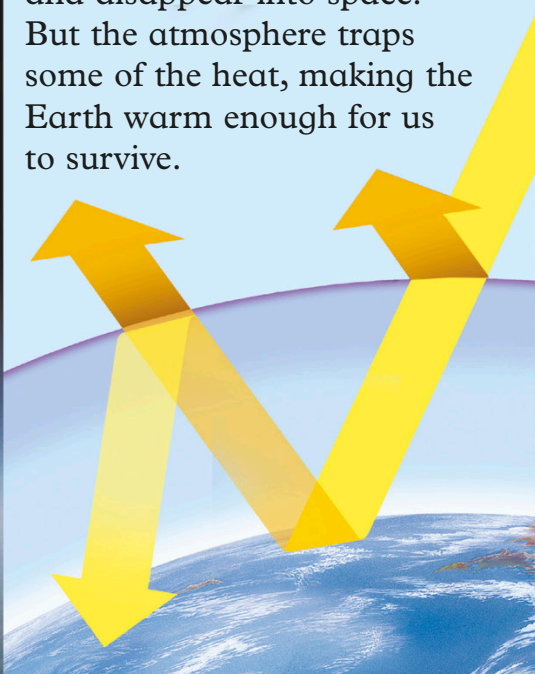
Planet Earth is wrapped in a thin layer of air called the atmosphere. Without this protective blanket of gases, life on the Earth could not exist.

Gases in air

Air is a mixture of different gases, including nitrogen, oxygen, and carbon dioxide. Oxygen is vital for plants and animals as it allows them to breathe. Carbon dioxide is also vital for plants. They absorb it from the air and use the carbon atoms to help build new leaves and stems.

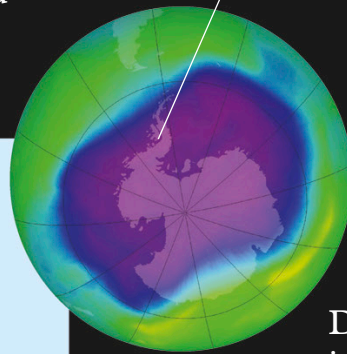
The greenhouse effect

If there was no atmosphere, the Sun's warming rays would bounce off the Earth and disappear into space. But the atmosphere traps some of the heat, making the Earth warm enough for us to survive.



Shimmering particles

The atmosphere is mainly made up of gases, but it also contains tiny particles of dust, pollen, and water droplets. All particles can cause a haze in the air when the Sun shines through them.



The purple area, where the ozone layer is the thinnest, is called the ozone hole.

Protective layer

A gas called ozone in the atmosphere protects the Earth from harmful rays in sunlight. This ozone layer has become thinner because of chemical pollution. During the spring season (August–October) in the Southern Hemisphere, an area of the ozone layer above Antarctica becomes much thinner than anywhere else. This “ozone hole” occurs every year.